

Mootaz Alhalak

Junior Security Specialist | Full-Stack Developer

I understand how systems are built — which means I know how they can be broken.

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PROFILE

Junior Security Specialist with a strong foundation in cybersecurity and a unique background in full-stack development. Trained in penetration testing, network security, and web application vulnerabilities, with real hands-on pentest reports (solo and team), TryHackMe lab practice, and an intensive internship where I scored 98.80% and ranked 2nd in my cohort.

SECURITY EXPERIENCE

Cyber Security Intern — focal X Agency

Syria | Sep 2025 – Dec 2025 · Score: 98.80% · Ranked 2nd · Certificate + Recommendation Letter from CEO

- Completed an intensive 4-month cybersecurity program covering network security, web application attacks, OS hardening, cryptography, malware analysis, and penetration testing fundamentals.
- Applied OWASP Top 10 concepts hands-on — identified and exploited SQL Injection, XSS, IDOR, and authentication failures in real lab environments.
- Worked with Burp Suite, Nmap, Metasploit, Hydra, Hashcat, WPScan, Nikto, and DirB in structured attack scenarios.
- Studied SIEM, IDS/IPS, Firewall, and VPN configuration — gained practical understanding of defensive security architecture.
- Covered cryptography: symmetric/asymmetric encryption, hashing, and digital certificates. Practiced OS hardening on Linux and Windows.

PENETRATION TESTING PROJECTS

Linux Server Pentest — Solo Report

Black-Box Penetration Test | focal X Academy | Jan 2026

- Performed a full black-box pentest on a Linux server (WordPress + FTP + SSH). Identified and exploited 4 critical/high vulnerabilities.
- Exploited a backdoored ProFTPD 1.3.3c service (CVSS 9.8) to gain unauthenticated remote root access.
- Discovered and exploited exposed SSH credentials, misconfigured sudo permissions for privilege escalation to root, and WordPress admin RCE.
- Completed full post-exploitation: maintained access via SSH backdoor, cleared logs, and documented findings in a professional security report.

Tools: Nmap, Metasploit, WPScan, Nikto, DirB, Hydra, Hashcat, Searchsploit

[View Report](#) ■

OWASP Juice Shop Pentest — Team Report

Black-Box Web Application Pentest | focal X Academy | Team of 4 | Jan 2026

- Led team pentest on OWASP Juice Shop (Angular + Node.js/Express), deployed via Docker. Identified 10 vulnerabilities — 7 rated Critical/High.
- Exploited SQL Injection (CVSS 9.8) to bypass authentication and gain admin access; cracked exposed MD5 password hashes offline using Hashcat.
- Exploited IDOR (basket ID manipulation), JWT session mismanagement (token replay after logout), DOM-based XSS, and file upload bypass.
- Performed brute-force attacks with Hydra, directory enumeration with DirB, and API interception with Burp Suite Proxy and Repeater.
- Covered 8 OWASP Top 10 (2021) categories: A01–A07, A09. Wrote a full professional pentest report with risk matrix, exploitation chain, and PoC evidence.

Tools: Burp Suite, Hydra, Hashcat, DirB, Browser DevTools, Docker, Manual Exploitation

[View Report](#) ■

TRYHACKME — HANDS-ON LAB PRACTICE

Practical Security Labs & CTF Rooms | Online | Ongoing

- Completed 18 rooms covering networking, web exploitation, offensive/defensive security, SIEM, cryptography, and malware analysis.

Completed rooms: *Introductory Networking · What is Networking · Networking Concepts · DNS in Detail · HTTP in Detail · How Websites Work · Putting It All Together · Linux Fundamentals Part 1 · Passive Reconnaissance · Active Reconnaissance · Nmap Live Host Discovery · Offensive Security Intro · Defensive Security Intro · Introduction to SIEM · Cryptography Basics · Malware Classification · Metasploit: Introduction · Vulnerabilities 101*

DEVELOPMENT EXPERIENCE

Full-Stack Developer — 90Soft

Syria | 2024 – Present

- Designed and built secure REST APIs across multiple large-scale production platforms — enforcing authentication, authorization, and input validation from the ground up.
- Architected backend systems with security in mind: implemented role-based access control, secure session management, and JWT-based authentication flows.
- Integrated third-party payment gateways securely — managing API key handling, request signing, and sensitive data protection in production environments.
- Contributed to 2+ production platforms serving real users, gaining deep knowledge of how web systems and APIs are structured — and where they are vulnerable.

MERN Stack Trainee — focal X Agency

Syria | Aug 2024 · Ranked 3rd · Recommendation Letter from CEO

- Completed intensive full-stack training; built and deployed web applications.

SKILLS

Security: OWASP Top 10, Web App & API Security, Penetration Testing, Vulnerability Assessment, Network Security, Authentication & Session Security, Cryptography, Malware Analysis Basics, SIEM & IDS/IPS

Security Tools: Burp Suite, Nmap, Metasploit, Wireshark, Hydra, Hashcat, DirB, WPScan, Nikto, Kali Linux, Docker

Development: Angular, Node.js, NestJS, React, MongoDB, SQL, REST API Design, JWT Auth, Git / GitHub

Automation: n8n

CERTIFICATIONS

Cyber Security Internship Certificate

focal X Agency · Dec 2025 · Score: 98.80% · Rank: 2nd | [View Certificate](#) ■

Foundations of Cybersecurity

Google / Coursera · Aug 2023 | [View Certificate](#) ■

Play It Safe: Manage Security Risks

Google / Coursera · Sep 2023 | [View Certificate](#) ■

Connect and Protect: Networks and Network Security

Google / Coursera · Sep 2023 | [View Certificate](#) ■

Tools of the Trade: Linux and SQL

Google / Coursera · Oct 2023 | [View Certificate](#) ■

MERN Stack Training Certificate

focal X Agency · Aug 2024 · Rank: 3rd

EDUCATION

Bachelor's Degree, Computer Science — Damascus University

5th Year (In Progress)

LANGUAGES

Arabic — Native | English — Intermediate